

notably in semifinal thrillers at the French Open and Indian Wells.

In 2024, the Big Two dominated the Grand Slam events as greedily as the Big Three once did. Sinner triumphed in the hard-court Majors at the Australian and US Opens, while Alcaraz prevailed on the French Open clay and Wimbledon grass.

Sinner needed every ounce of his preternatural equanimity during his breakthrough season. In the Australian Open final, Daniil Medvedev came within six points of the title, with Sinner serving at 4-all, 40-all in the third set. But the Russian choked, making two unforced forehand errors, and the momentum abruptly shifted. Serving for the championship at 5-3, 30-all in the deciding set, the 22-year-old Italian calmly unleashed two point-winning forehands to secure a 3-6, 3-6, 6-4, 6-4, 6-3 victory and his first Grand Slam title.

If Sinner's passionate fans were nervous wrecks during these crises, their hero wasn't. "I like to dance in the pressure storm," he said afterwards. "I like it because that's where most of the time I bring out my best tennis."

Sinner won eight tournaments, led Italy to its second consecutive Davis Cup title, and racked up an amazing 73-6 match record, but the stress took its toll. In November, he confided, "I've kept thinking about where we went wrong and what we could have done better. I had days where I wasn't feeling great; nights when I didn't sleep well."

Alcaraz also had his mettle tested in an up-and-down year. At the French Open, he needed a painkiller and a massage from the trainer in the fourth set of the final against Alexander Zverev but pulled off a 6-3, 2-6, 5-7, 6-1, 6-2 triumph. At 21, the Spanish sorcerer became the youngest man to win Grand Slam titles on hard, clay, and grass courts, edging Nadal, who achieved the feat at 22 during the 2009 Australian Open. The dramatic final



Flourishing rivalry: Sinner (above) won eight tournaments, led Italy to its second consecutive Davis Cup title, and racked up an amazing 73-6 match record. Meanwhile, Alcaraz (right) won four titles overall, including the French Open and Wimbledon, beating Sinner multiple times along the way.

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overshadowed an even closer, higher-quality semifinal, where Alcaraz overcame Sinner 2-6, 6-3, 3-6, 6-4, 6-3. Afterwards, Alcaraz channelled his boyhood idol Nadal when he told the crowd, "You have to find the joy in suffering. That's the key."

Changing of the guard

Before the Wimbledon final, *ESPN* analyst Patrick McEnroe correctly predicted, "The changing of the guard becomes official today." How fitting that on the 150th anniversary of modern tennis — which began on grass in Victorian England — the sport's undisputed GOAT faced a

